

L04 — Linear Arrays: Representation and Traversal

Unit: 1 | Chapter: Fundamentals of Data Structures & Arrays | BT Level: BT4 | CO: CO1, CO2

Learning Objectives

- Describe how arrays are stored in memory (row-major and column-major)
 - Calculate the address of any element using the base address formula
 - Implement array traversal in different patterns
 - Analyze the time and space complexity of traversal operations
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1. What is an Array?

An **array** is a collection of elements of the **same data type** stored in **contiguous memory locations**, accessed by an integer **index**.

Index:	0	1	2	3	4
Value:	[10]	[25]	[37]	[42]	[58]
	↑				
	Base address (BA)				

Key properties:

- Fixed size (declared at creation)
 - $O(1)$ random access via index
 - Homogeneous elements (same type)
 - Zero-indexed (in C, Java, Python) or one-indexed (in Fortran, MATLAB)
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2. Memory Representation of a 1D Array

Each element occupies a fixed number of bytes determined by its data type:

Type	Size
int (C)	4 bytes
double (C)	8 bytes
char (C)	1 byte

Address Calculation Formula

$$\text{Address}(A[i]) = \text{BA} + i \times \text{size}$$

where:

- **BA** = Base address of array
- **i** = Index of element
- **size** = Size of each element in bytes

Example: BA = 1000, int array, find address of A[3]: $\text{Address}(A[3]) = 1000 + 3 \times 4 = 1012$

3. 2D Array Representation

A 2D array A[m][n] has m rows and n columns.

3.1 Row-Major Order (C, C++, Java, Python)

Elements are stored **row by row**:

A[0][0], A[0][1], A[0][2], A[1][0], A[1][1], A[1][2], ...

Address Formula (0-indexed): $\text{Address}(A[i][j]) = \text{BA} + (i \times n + j) \times \text{size}$

Example: BA = 2000, int 3×4 array, find A[2][1]: $\text{Address} = 2000 + (2 \times 4 + 1) \times 4 = 2000 + 9 \times 4 = 2036$

3.2 Column-Major Order (Fortran, MATLAB)

Elements are stored **column by column**:

A[0][0], A[1][0], A[2][0], A[0][1], A[1][1], A[2][1], ...

Address Formula (0-indexed): $\text{Address}(A[i][j]) = \text{BA} + (j \times m + i) \times \text{size}$

4. Array Traversal

Traversal means visiting each element exactly once to read or process it.

4.1 Linear Traversal — O(n)

```
def traverse(arr):
    n = len(arr)
    for i in range(n):
        print(arr[i])    # Process each element
```

Time Complexity: O(n) — visits each of n elements once

Space Complexity: O(1) — no extra memory beyond index variable

4.2 Reverse Traversal — O(n)

```
def traverse_reverse(arr):
    n = len(arr)
```

```
for i in range(n - 1, -1, -1):
    print(arr[i])
```

4.3 2D Array Traversal — $O(m \times n)$

```
def traverse_2d(matrix, m, n):
    for i in range(m):          # O(m)
        for j in range(n):      # O(n)
            print(matrix[i][j]) # O(1)
# Total: O(m × n)
```

4.4 Traversal Patterns (Interview Common)

```
# Diagonal traversal of a square matrix
def diagonal_traverse(matrix, n):
    for i in range(n):
        print(matrix[i][i])    # O(n)

# Spiral traversal (used in competitive programming)
def spiral_traverse(matrix, m, n):
    top, bottom, left, right = 0, m-1, 0, n-1
    while top <= bottom and left <= right:
        for i in range(left, right + 1):
            print(matrix[top][i])
        top += 1
        for i in range(top, bottom + 1):
            print(matrix[i][right])
        right -= 1
        if top <= bottom:
            for i in range(right, left - 1, -1):
                print(matrix[bottom][i])
            bottom -= 1
        if left <= right:
            for i in range(bottom, top - 1, -1):
                print(matrix[i][left])
            left += 1
```

5. Advantages and Disadvantages of Arrays

Advantages

Feature	Detail
Random access	$O(1)$ access via index
Cache-friendly	Contiguous memory → good spatial locality
Simple implementation	No pointer overhead

Disadvantages

Limitation	Detail
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Fixed size	Must declare size upfront
Costly insertion/deletion	Shifting elements → $O(n)$
Wasted space	Pre-allocated size may go unused
Homogeneous	All elements must be same type

6. Complexity Summary

Operation	Time Complexity	Space Complexity
Access $A[i]$	$O(1)$	$O(1)$
Traverse all	$O(n)$	$O(1)$
2D Traverse	$O(m \times n)$	$O(1)$
Address calculation	$O(1)$	$O(1)$

7. Practical Code Example

```
# Complete example: declare, initialize, traverse, and find max
def array_operations():
    arr = [64, 34, 25, 12, 22, 11, 90]
    n = len(arr)

    # Traversal
    print("Array elements:")
    for i in range(n):
        print(f"arr[{i}] = {arr[i]}")

    # Finding maximum during traversal
    max_val = arr[0]
    max_idx = 0
    for i in range(1, n):
        if arr[i] > max_val:
            max_val = arr[i]
            max_idx = i

    print(f"Maximum: {max_val} at index {max_idx}")

array_operations()
```

Output:

```
arr[0] = 64
arr[1] = 34
...
arr[6] = 90
Maximum: 90 at index 6
```

Summary

- Arrays store homogeneous elements in **contiguous memory** — enabling $O(1)$ access.
 - **Address formula:** $BA + i \times \text{size}$ (1D); $BA + (i \times n + j) \times \text{size}$ (2D, row-major).
 - **Traversal** visits each element once $\rightarrow O(n)$ for 1D, $O(m \times n)$ for 2D.
 - Row-major (C/Java/Python) vs column-major (Fortran/MATLAB) affects traversal efficiency.
 - Arrays excel at random access; they struggle with dynamic resizing and mid-array insertion.
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References

- Cormen et al., *Introduction to Algorithms*, Ch. 10.1 (MIT Press, 2022)
- Skiena, *The Algorithm Design Manual*, Ch. 3.2 (Springer, 2020)
- Laaksonen, *Guide to Competitive Programming*, Ch. 4.1 (Springer, 2024)